

Professional Ethics for Information Technology

Chapter-One

AN OVERVIEW OF ETHICS

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Course objective

} The course will give an insight into the meaning of a professional and morale behavior in relation to information technology. Also some ethical theories as well as moral problems within informatics are discussed from a global point of view. International organizations professional codes of ethics and aspects of integrity, privacy, IPR(Intellectual property Management) and spam will be analysed. Teaching consists of lectures and seminars is carried out in groups with some mandatory activities. Assessment is performed in written examination and in presentations.

AN OVERVIEW OF ETHICS

- } Each society forms a set of rules that establishes the boundaries of generally accepted behavior.
- } These rules are often expressed in statements about how people should behave, and they fit together to form the moral code by which a society lives.
- } The term morality refers to social conventions about right and wrong.
- } However, individual views of what is moral may vary by age, cultural group, ethnic background, religion, life experiences, education, and gender.

Ethics in general:

- The set of beliefs about *right and wrong* behavior within a society.
- Ethical behavior conforms to generally accepted norms/standards—many of which are almost universal.
- For instance, everyone would agree that lying and cheating are unethical.
- For example, attitudes toward **software piracy**—that is, the practice of illegally making copies of software or enabling others to access software to

Ethics In Practice (Applied Ethics)

Ethics is founded in a society' s *moral code*

- the rules (conventions) by which a society lives (an established consensus)

Moral code tested in real-life situations, such as:

- "Is getting an abortion immoral?"
- "Is affirmative action right or wrong?"
- "What are human rights, and how do we determine them?"
- "Do animals have rights as well? "
- "Is lying always wrong?" and "If not, when is it permissible? "

Personal Ethics

- ❖ Rules/morals (habits) you have acquired when growing up (and still acquire/modify as you live on)
- ❖ People also develop habits that make it easier to choose between what society considers good or bad.
- ❖ **Virtues** are habits/conducts that incline people to do what is acceptable, and **vices** are habits of unacceptable behavior.

Virtues:(**good**) habits that incline people to do what is acceptable, such as fairness, generosity, honesty, loyalty.

Vices:(**bad**) habits of unacceptable behavior

- Vanity, Envy, Greed/selfish, Anger
- Good corresponding habits: pride, admiration, ambition, force.

Moral

1. Moral

Morals are personal beliefs about what is **right and wrong**. They come from an individual's upbringing, culture, religion, or personal values.

Characteristics:

- Personal and internal
- Varies from person to person
- Not formally written

Example in IT:

A programmer refuses to create malware because they personally believe harming others is wrong.

Ethics

2. Ethics

Ethics are **rules or standards of behavior** accepted by a **profession or society**. In IT, ethics guide how professionals should behave while working.

Characteristics:

- ❖ Shared by a profession or organization
- ❖ Often written as a **code of ethics**
- ❖ Guides professional behavior

Example: The Association for Computing Machinery (**ACM**) and Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (**IEEE**) have **codes of ethics** for IT professionals.

Example in IT:

- i. Not accessing or sharing users' private data without permission.
- ii. Reporting software vulnerabilities responsibly.

Laws

Laws are official rules created and enforced by governments. They define what actions are legally acceptable or punishable.

Characteristics:

- Written and formal
- Enforced by government
- Violating them leads to legal penalties (fine, prison, etc.)

Example in IT:

- Hacking into a system without authorization is illegal.
- Distributing pirated software violates copyright laws.

Simple Way to Remember

Morals → Personal values

Ethics → Professional standards

Laws → Government rules

✓ Example Scenario in IT

A developer finds a way to secretly collect users' data.

Moral: They feel it is wrong to spy on people.

Ethics: Professional codes say user privacy must be protected.

Law: Data protection laws may punish illegal data collection.

Important Test for Morals and Integrity: Truth/Lie

A lie is a deception/dishonesty in the form of an untruthful statement.

- *Lie* is a statement of something that is false with the intention that it be taken for the truth by oneself or someone else
- It is motivated by maintaining a secret or reputation, protecting someone's feelings or to avoid a punishment,
- But there are different forms of lies, which challenge personal judgements of situational integrity and ethics
- **Severity of lie depends on context, situation and intent**
- need a moral understanding when to refrain from lying.
- children do not have this
- some adults are habitual liars

Forms of Lies

There are many forms of lies:

- **fabrication**: a statement not based on fact
- **bald-faced lie**: obvious lie
- **lying by omission**: leave out an important fact
- **lie-to-children**: simplification (the stork brought you)
- **white lie**: harmless lie to avoid harmful implication.
- **emergency lie**: strategic lie when it is dangerous to tell the truth
- **perjury**: false statement in court
- **misleading**: lie aimed to guide to untruth
- **promotion lies**: in advertising (you will love our new product)
- **jacose lies**: sarcasm, storytelling, comedy

Why Fostering Good Business Ethics Is Important

- ✓ B/C, Organizations have at least five good reasons for promoting a work environment in which employees are encouraged to act ethically when making business decisions:

1. Gaining the good will of the community

2. Creating an organization that operates consistently

3. Fostering good business practices

Gaining the Good Will of the Community

- The organizations exist primarily to earn profits or provide services to customers.
- They also have some fundamental responsibilities to society.
- Often they declare these responsibilities in a formal statement of their company's principles or beliefs.
- The fact that they organization have to attract and maintain loyalty with their

Creating an Organization That Operates Consistently

- Organizations develop and abide by values to create an organizational culture and to define a consistent approach for dealing with the needs of their stakeholders—shareholders, employees, customers, suppliers, and the community.
- Such consistency means that employees know what is expected of them and can employ the organization's values to help them in their decision making.
- Consistency also means that shareholders, customers, suppliers, and the community know what they can expect of the organization.
- It is especially important for multinational or global organizations to present a consistent face

Creating an Organization that Operates Consistently

Many business values include:

- ✓ Operating with honesty and integrity, staying true to corporate principles
- ✓ Operating according to standards of ethical conduct, in words and action
- ✓ Treating colleagues, customers, and consumers (called stakeholders) with respect
- ✓ Accepting personal responsibility for actions
- ✓ Valuing diversity
- ✓ Making decisions based on facts and

Fostering Good Business Practices

- ✓ In many cases, good ethics can mean good business and improved profits.
- ✓ Companies that provide excellent service retain their customers instead of losing them to competitors.
- ✓ Companies that develop and maintain strong employee relations suffer lower turnover rates and enjoy better employee morale.
- ✓ Suppliers and other business partners prefer companies that operate in a fair and ethical manner.

Avoiding Unfavorable Publicity

- ✓ Thus, many organizations are motivated to build a strong ethics program to avoid negative publicity.
- ✓ If an organization is perceived as operating ethically, customers, business partners, shareholders, consumer advocates, financial institutions, and regulatory bodies will usually regard it more favorably.
- ✓ The public reputation of a company strongly

Computer Ethics

- Computer ethics is a form of applied or practical ethics.
- Computer ethics is a concept in ethics that addresses the ethical issues and constraints that arise from the use of computers.
- It studies the moral questions that are associated with the development, application, and use of computers.
- Posing ethical questions about privacy, software patents, responsibility for software errors, equal access, and

Ethics in Information Technology

✓ Trends contributing to the risk of using IT unethically:

- growth of the Internet
- ability to capture and store vast amounts of personal data online
- greater reliance/dependence on information systems in all aspects of life.

✓ Public concern about ethical use of IT includes:

- E-mail and Internet access *monitoring* by employers
- Peer-to-peer networks used for music downloads implies *violation of copyright laws and without charge*.
- Unsolicited e-mail (*spam*)
- Hackers breaking into databases of financial institutions can result in *identify theft and* to steal customer information.
- Students downloading material from web can result in *plagiarism*
- Web sites plant cookies or spyware on visitors' hard drives to *track their Internet activity*

Ethics in Information Technology

- ✓ The general public has not realized the critical importance of ethics as applied to IT
 - ✓ IT policies can affect millions
- ✓ Important technical decisions often left to technical experts
- ✓ General business managers must assume greater responsibility for these decisions
 - Must be able to make broad-minded, objective, ethical decisions based on technical savvy, business know-how, and a sense of ethics
 - Must also try to create a working environment in which ethical dilemmas can be discussed openly, objectively, and constructively.

Summary

- ✓ Ethics is a set of beliefs about *right and wrong* behavior.
- ✓ Ethics is important since it *respects trust* placed by customers and colleagues.
- ✓ Ethics in business is becoming more important because the *risks associated with inappropriate behavior have grown* in number, complexity, likelihood and significance.
- ✓ Corporations can appoint a corporate ethics officer, set ethical standards, establish a *code of ethics*, conduct *audits*, require employees to take *ethics training*.

Ethical Decision Making: 7 Step Approach

#1: Get the facts

- innocent situations can become controversies if no one bothers to check the facts

#2: Identify stakeholders

- someone who stands to lose or gain from how a situation is resolved and their positions

#3: Consider the consequences of a decision on stakeholders

#4: Weigh various guidelines and principles, legal implications, corporate policies

#5: Develop and evaluate options you choose

- these should be ethically defensible

#6: Review a decision

- consider POV (Point of View) of stakeholders

#7: Evaluate the results of a decision

- monitor results to see if achieve desired effect

Establishing a Corporate Code of Ethics

- A code of ethics is a statement that highlights an organization's key ethical issues.
- The code frequently includes a set of formal, written statements about the purpose of the organization, its values, and the principles that should guide its employees' actions.
- An organization's code of ethics applies to its directors, officers, and employees.
- The code of ethics focuses employees on areas of ethical risk relating to their role in the organization, offers guidance to help them recognize and deal with ethical issues, and provides mechanisms for reporting unethical conduct and fostering a culture of honesty and

Requiring Employees to Take Ethics Training

- The ancient Greek philosophers believed that personal convictions about right and wrong behavior could be improved through education.
- Today, most psychologists agree with them.
- Other researchers have repeatedly supported the idea that people can continue their moral development through further education.
- Ethics training not only makes employees more aware of a company's code of ethics and how to apply it, but also demonstrates that the company intends to operate in an ethical manner.
- Organizations can do this by showing employees examples of how to apply the code of ethics in real life.
- One approach is through a comprehensive ethics

Creating an Ethical Work Environment

- Most employees want to perform their jobs successfully and ethically, but good employees sometimes make bad ethical choices.
- Employees in highly competitive workplaces often feel pressure from aggressive competitors, cutthroat suppliers, unrealistic budgets, unforgiving quotas, tight deadlines, and bonus incentives.
- Such environments can make some employees feel pressure to engage in unethical conduct to meet management's

Thank You!

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